QUIET LUXURY

Timeless designs dominate the 2026 wrist

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Over the past two years, rising prices of precious metals as well as dramatic changes to international trade relationships—especially U.S. tariffs—have rocked the luxury watch industry. In response, nearly all the brands have raised prices significantly.

As a prime example, Rolex's recent behavior has been alarming. For decades, Rolex quietly raised its prices in January, usually by around 3% to 5%. However, in January of 2025, Rolex increased prices on steel models at the normal rate, while precious metal models shot up as much as 14% in response to spiking gold prices. Then, on May 1st of that year, Rolex raised prices a second time by an estimated 4% in response to proposed U.S. tariffs hikes. Cut to 2026, and Rolex gave a fulsome 7% increase in January, followed by yet another secondary hike in June of about 3.5% across its catalogue.

None of this was normal.

According to the New York Times, luxury watch brands have raised prices roughly 7% over the course of 2026 (so far). These are some of the steepest price increases for luxury watches in recent history, stretching from the top-tier brands down to even the more affordable options.

How does this financial situation impact the creation of watches?

A walk through the halls of Geneva's Watches and Wonders trade show last April gave the impression of an industry no longer willing to push trendy colorways and bejeweled rainbow bezels out to a voracious market of new collectors spurred on by the pandemic. Instead, this year saw brands from Cartier to Patek Philippe, Jaeger-LeCoultre and Panerai return to core models and relatively traditional horology.

The focus on restrained aesthetics and mechanical complications may come as a welcome shift for those who value quiet luxury and high-craft over blingy trends. To be fair, bold colours did not disappear entirely, as evidenced by offerings from avant-garde brands like Moser, Hublot, Richard Mille and Zenith. But if we turn to the likes of Patek Philippe, Vacheron Constantin and even the more daring Audemars Piguet—together known as the Holy Trinity of Swiss watchmaking—the focus is certainly on honouring the back-catalogue and refining mechanics.

Speaking of high-horology back catalogues, Breguet celebrates the 225th anniversary of its storied tourbillon complication this year, which was invented by the brand's founder. To celebrate, Breguet has offered up four tourbillon models that epitomise classic horology.

There is also a focus on thinness this year, once one of the great horological challenges, with Piaget having long been at the forefront. This year, Vacheron Constantin, Piaget, Bulgari, Nomos Glashütte, Patek Philippe, Jaeger-LeCoultre and A. Lange & Söhne all offered up impressively thin models, indicating what some feel is a demand for more discrete forms of luxury on the wrist.

It's no surprise that smaller diameters are also making their way into most catalogues again.

Longines refreshed its classically styled Master Collection, offering sizes from 30mm up to 41mm. Meanwhile Omega trimmed an impressive 2.31mm of height off its flagship diver, the Planet Ocean. Frederique Constant brought out the 37mm Moneta Solarmetre at just 8.52mm tall, and Chopard made both its Alpine Eagle and L.U.C. models much thinner.

We have rounded up some of the most impressive timepieces of 2026 below.